

Here is a detailed breakdown of who proposed the **Lehigh County Home Rule Charter Referendum Questions**, why they are on the ballot, and the primary arguments surrounding each measure.

Who Proposed These Referendums?

All three countywide questions were formally sponsored and placed on the ballot by the **Lehigh County Board of Commissioners** (the 9-member elected legislative branch of Lehigh County government) via county ordinance. Under Pennsylvania's Home Rule Charter law, changes to the foundational rules of county governance must be passed by the Commissioners and then submitted to voters for final referendum approval.

1. Expansion & Partisan Composition of the Election Commission (Question 1)

- **The Proposal:** Expands the Election and Registration Commission from 3 members to 5 members. Instead of the traditional setup (1 Democrat, 1 Republican, and the County Executive or an appointee), it mandates 2 Democrats, 2 Republicans, and 1 member from the third-largest political group in the county (an Independent or unaffiliated registered voter).
- **Why It Was Introduced:** As non-affiliated and Independent registration has grown significantly in Lehigh County, sponsors wanted to grant non-party voters official representation in election administration and avoid potential conflicts of interest when an incumbent County Executive is on the election board while running for re-election.

Majority / Pro Arguments ("YES")

- **Fair Representation:** Unaffiliated and Independent voters represent a growing portion of Lehigh County residents; giving them a designated seat ensures the board reflects the actual electorate.
- **Nonpartisan Integrity:** A 5-member board with a balanced 2-2-1 structure prevents either major political party from holding a partisan voting bloc or dominating election certification decisions.
- **Shared Workload:** Expanding membership helps distribute the heavy administrative duties of reviewing mail-in ballots, setting polling places, and hearing voter registration appeals.

Minority / Con Arguments ("NO")

- **Added Overhead:** Opponents note that adding two board positions increases administrative costs and stipend payouts for county operations.
- **Selection Concerns:** Critics express concern over how "Independent" members are vetted, worrying that the third member could become a partisan tie-breaker or lead to political maneuvering over board appointments.
- **Status Quo Sufficiency:** Opponents argue the existing 3-member board has successfully managed elections without needing structural expansion.

2. Legal Newspaper Notice Requirements (Question 2)

- **The Proposal:** Amends the charter to allow Lehigh County to publish mandatory public notices in **at least one** newspaper of general circulation rather than requiring publication in **two separate** newspapers.
- **Why It Was Introduced:** Print newspaper readership has declined, and the number of daily print newspapers operating in the Lehigh Valley has shrunk over time. County commissioners introduced this to reduce redundant spending on expensive print legal ads.

Majority / Pro Arguments ("YES")

- **Taxpayer Savings:** Reduces county advertising expenses by eliminating duplicate print notices.
- **Modern Media Habits:** Acknowledges that citizens increasingly obtain official public information through digital sources and county web portals rather than print newspapers.

Minority / Con Arguments ("NO")

- **Reduced Transparency:** Critics argue that cutting notice requirements from two publications to one reduces the overall visibility of county government actions, particularly for elderly residents or communities reliant on local print media.
- **Impact on Local Press:** Legal notice advertising provides an important revenue stream for local community newspapers, which opponents argue shouldn't be cut back.

3. Retirement Board Representation (Question 3)

- **The Proposal:** Removes the mandatory requirement that the **Chair** of the Board of Commissioners personally hold a seat on the Lehigh County Retirement Board, allowing Commissioners to designate **any** member of their board to fill that seat.
- **Why It Was Introduced:** The Board Chair carries significant legislative and administrative duties. The change allows the Board to delegate pension oversight to a commissioner who has specific financial expertise or additional time to commit.

Majority / Pro Arguments ("YES")

- **Flexibility & Expertise:** Lets the Board of Commissioners assign a member with relevant experience in finance, investments, or human resources to manage county employee pension oversight.
- **Workload Relief:** Prevents bottlenecks by ensuring the Board Chair isn't overburdened with conflicting committee schedules.

Minority / Con Arguments ("NO")

- **Direct Accountability:** Opponents feel the top leader of the legislative branch (the Board Chair) should remain directly accountable for decisions regarding county pension funds.
- **Unnecessary Charter Change:** Opponents view the amendment as an unnecessary

administrative tweak that doesn't warrant changing the county charter.

(Note: If you reside in specific townships within Lehigh County, such as North Whitehall Township, you may also see local municipal ballot questions on your ballot, such as open-space land preservation tax referendums.)